

TITLE: 10 BEST PLACES TO LIVE IN BRITISH COLUMBIA (2026 GUIDE)

[INTRO – ~2 minutes]

[On camera]

Hey everyone, welcome back to the channel. In today's video we're talking about one of the most beautiful places on earth: **British Columbia, Canada**.

If you've ever thought about moving to B.C. – or just wondered where the BEST places to live are – this video is for you. I'm going to walk you through **10 of the top places to live in British Columbia in 2026**, based on quality of life, amenities, access to nature, and what different rankings and local opinions are saying.

We'll look at a mix of big cities, suburbs, and small towns: places like Vancouver, Victoria, Nanaimo, North Vancouver, Oak Bay, Saanich, New Westminster, Langley, Kimberley, and Tofino.

For each one, I'll give you:

- A quick description of what it's like to live there.
- The kind of person or lifestyle it suits.
- A fun fact about the area.
- And I'll drop links in the description so you can check rankings and more info for yourself.

This isn't formal immigration or financial advice – it's a lifestyle guide to help you narrow down your research. Always double-check details like housing costs, job markets, and visa requirements for your own situation.

Alright, let's jump into the list.

1. NANAIMO – VANCOUVER ISLAND'S RISING STAR

Estimated segment length: ~2–2.5 minutes

[On camera + B-roll of Nanaimo waterfront]

First up at number one is **Nanaimo**, a mid-sized city on Vancouver Island that's been getting a lot of attention.

Recent quality-of-life rankings have placed Nanaimo at or near the top for **best quality of life in British Columbia**, and even among the top cities in all of Canada. It scores well on safety, healthcare access, and overall livability, while still being more affordable than Vancouver or Victoria.

Nanaimo sits on the east coast of Vancouver Island, with a long, walkable waterfront, ferry connections to the mainland, and quick access to forests, lakes, and beaches. It's big enough to have shopping, schools, and services, but small enough that traffic is manageable and nature is never far away.

Who is Nanaimo best for? It's great if you want a balanced lifestyle: not too big, not too small. It's popular with families, retirees, and remote workers who want a coastal city that doesn't feel overwhelming.

Fun fact about Nanaimo: The city is famous for the **Nanaimo bar**, a no-bake dessert bar that's become a Canadian classic – and yes, it really is named after Nanaimo.

Links for more on Nanaimo and livability rankings:

<https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/british-columbia/nanaimo-numbeo-ranking-9.7046073>

<https://www.areavibes.com/best-places/british+columbia/>

2. VICTORIA – CAPITAL CITY WITH MILD WEATHER

Estimated segment length: ~2 minutes

[On camera + B-roll of Inner Harbour]

Number two is **Victoria**, the capital city of British Columbia.

Victoria shows up again and again on lists of Canada's most livable cities. It's known for its mild climate, beautiful harbour, walkable downtown, and strong services, thanks in part to all the government, education, and tourism activity.

Living in Victoria means you get a European-feeling small city – with historic buildings, cafes, and a compact core – plus easy access to the ocean and nature trails. It's a big draw for retirees, students, professionals, and anyone who wants a calmer alternative to Vancouver.

Housing can be expensive, but often still a bit more manageable than Metro Vancouver. If you pair that with lower snow levels and year-round greenery, it's easy to see why so many people want to live here.

Fun fact about Victoria: Victoria is often called the **"City of Gardens"** because of its countless private gardens, flower-lined streets, and the famous Butchart Gardens nearby.

Links for Victoria and best-places info:

<https://canadianimmigrant.ca/settlement/living-in-canada/canadas-most-livable-cities-2026>

<https://livingcost.org/best/canada/bc>

3. VANCOUVER – WORLD-CLASS CITY BY THE OCEAN

Estimated segment length: ~2–2.5 minutes

[On camera + skyline, seawall, mountains]

Number three is the one you've probably heard of already: **Vancouver**.

Vancouver is a global city – known around the world for its skyline, its mountains-meet-ocean scenery, and its multicultural population. It consistently ranks highly for quality of life, access to nature, and overall attractiveness as a place to live and work.

If you're in tech, film, academia, or professional services, Vancouver offers lots of opportunities. You've got universities like UBC and SFU, major employers, and endless outdoor options: skiing, hiking, biking, kayaking – often all within an hour of the city.

The big downside? Housing. Vancouver is one of the most expensive cities in Canada, and affordability is a major issue. It's best suited to people who either have higher incomes, are willing to live smaller, or see the city as a long-term lifestyle investment.

Fun fact about Vancouver: Vancouver's Stanley Park is larger than New York's Central Park and has a famous seawall where locals walk, cycle, and run with ocean and mountain views.

Links for Vancouver lifestyle and rankings:

<https://germyn.ca/where-to-live-in-british-columbia-the-real-breakdown-2026-guide/>

<https://livingcost.org/best/canada/bc>

4. NORTH VANCOUVER – OUTDOOR LOVER'S PARADISE

Estimated segment length: ~2 minutes

[On camera + B-roll of North Shore mountains]

Number four is **North Vancouver**, often simply called “North Van”.

North Vancouver is technically a separate municipality from Vancouver, on the north side of Burrard Inlet, and it repeatedly shows up as one of the **best places to live in Canada** for people who love the outdoors. You’re right at the base of the North Shore mountains, with quick access to hiking, skiing, mountain biking, and stunning viewpoints.

It’s also very family-friendly, with good schools, quiet neighbourhoods, and that combination of urban access plus nature that many people dream about.

Like Vancouver, North Van isn’t cheap – housing costs are high – but if your priority is lifestyle, scenery, and raising a family close to nature, it’s hard to beat.

Fun fact about North Vancouver: North Van is home to the famous **Grouse Grind**, a steep hiking trail sometimes called “Mother Nature’s Stairmaster,” where people test their fitness by racing up the mountain.

Links for North Vancouver and best-place lists:

<https://wildindigohome.ca/best-places-to-live-in-canada-2026/>

<https://livingcost.org/best/canada/bc>

5. OAK BAY – CHARMING SEASIDE COMMUNITY (GREATER VICTORIA)

Estimated segment length: ~2 minutes

[On camera + B-roll of Oak Bay Village, seaside]

Number five is **Oak Bay**, one of the most desirable small communities in the Greater Victoria area.

Oak Bay is a seaside municipality known for its tree-lined streets, older character homes, and walkable village centre with cafes, shops, and galleries. It frequently ranks near the top of “best towns to live in B.C.” lists, especially for people who want safety, charm, and a strong community feel.

It’s popular with retirees and well-established families, and housing prices reflect that – Oak Bay is not cheap. But if your budget allows, it offers one of the most picturesque and comfortable small-town lifestyles in the province, just minutes from downtown Victoria.

Fun fact about Oak Bay: Oak Bay has several beautiful beaches and rocky shorelines, and it’s one of the best places around Victoria to spot **marine life** like seals and sometimes even killer whales offshore.

Links for Oak Bay and “best towns” rankings:

<https://www.areavibes.com/best-places/british+columbia/>

<https://ca.finance.yahoo.com/news/best-towns-live-bc-113600693.html>

6. SAANICH – GREEN, FAMILY-FRIENDLY SUBURB (GREATER VICTORIA)

Estimated segment length: ~2 minutes

[On camera + B-roll of parks, neighbourhoods]

Number six is **Saanich**, a large suburban municipality that surrounds much of Victoria.

Saanich scores very well on livability indexes, often with ratings in the mid-80s out of 100. It offers a mix of established neighbourhoods, parks, farms, and even some semi-rural pockets. You can find everything from student-friendly areas near the University of Victoria to quiet family streets and small acreages.

If you want to be close to Victoria without living right downtown, Saanich is a popular choice. There's lots of green space, trails, lakes, and a strong sense of being in a "leafy suburb" rather than a dense city.

Fun fact about Saanich: Saanich has a surprising amount of **farmland** within its borders. The rural parts of Saanich are part of the province's Agricultural Land Reserve, helping preserve local farming close to the city.

Links for Saanich livability and details:

<https://www.areavibes.com/best-places/british+columbia/>

<https://livingcost.org/best/canada/bc>

7. NEW WESTMINSTER – HISTORIC CITY WITH GOOD TRANSIT

Estimated segment length: ~2 minutes

[On camera + B-roll of riverfront and downtown]

Number seven is **New Westminster**, located on the Fraser River just east of Vancouver.

New West is a smaller, historic city that consistently appears near the top of B.C. livability lists. It has a walkable downtown, a lively riverfront, good access to transit – including SkyTrain connections into Vancouver – and a mix of condos and older houses.

Compared to Vancouver itself, New West can offer slightly more attainable housing while still giving you an urban lifestyle. It's popular with young professionals, couples, and families who want city life without being right in the downtown core.

Fun fact about New Westminster: New West used to be the **capital of British Columbia** back in the 1800s, which is why it's sometimes called the "Royal City."

Links for New Westminster rankings and info:

<https://www.areavibes.com/best-places/british+columbia/>

<https://livingcost.org/best/canada/bc>

8. LANGLEY – SUBURBAN MEETS COUNTRY (METRO VANCOUVER / FRASER VALLEY)

Estimated segment length: ~2 minutes

[On camera + B-roll of Langley farms and suburbs]

Number eight is **Langley**, in the eastern part of Metro Vancouver.

Langley is often rated as one of the best places to live in B.C. in terms of livability scores. It offers a mix of suburban neighbourhoods, shopping areas, and nearby farmland and wineries. You can live in a typical subdivision, or you can choose a more rural acreage lifestyle while still having access to city services.

It's a strong option for families and people who want more space, a yard, and maybe even a small hobby farm, but still need to commute into other parts of the Lower Mainland.

Fun fact about Langley: Langley calls itself the ***"Birthplace of B.C."** because Fort Langley – now a National Historic Site – was one of the earliest Hudson's Bay Company posts and played a key role in the early colony.

Links for Langley livability and more:

<https://www.areavibes.com/best-places/british+columbia/>

<https://ca.finance.yahoo.com/news/best-towns-live-bc-113600693.html>

9. KIMBERLEY – MOUNTAIN TOWN VOTED B.C.'S BEST SMALL TOWN

Estimated segment length: ~2–2.5 minutes

[On camera + B-roll of ski hill / town centre]

Number nine takes us to the Kootenays: **Kimberley**.

Kimberley was voted **B.C.'s best small town** in a CBC reader competition, beating out dozens of other communities across the province. It's a mountain town with a ski resort, hiking and biking trails, and a relaxed, friendly atmosphere.

Housing tends to be more affordable than in the big coastal cities, which makes it attractive for people who can work remotely or who want a lifestyle based around outdoor recreation instead of big-city careers.

If you dream of skiing in the winter, mountain biking in the summer, and being part of a tight-knit community, Kimberley should definitely be on your radar.

Fun fact about Kimberley: The town has a unique Bavarian-themed pedestrian plaza called the **Platzl**, which gives the downtown a European alpine village feel.

Links for Kimberley as B.C.'s best small town:

<https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/british-columbia/kimberley-best-small-town-bc-winner-1.6434796>

<https://banffnationalpark.com/12-best-small-towns-in-british-columbia/>

10. TOFINO – SURF TOWN ON THE EDGE OF THE PACIFIC

Estimated segment length: ~2–2.5 minutes

[On camera + B-roll of beaches and waves]

And finally, number ten: **Tofino**, on the wild west coast of Vancouver Island.

Tofino consistently shows up on lists of the **best small towns in British Columbia**. It's a tiny community famous for its surfing, storm watching, beaches, and rugged Pacific coastline. It's surrounded by rainforest and the ocean, and it has a strong tourism-based economy.

Living in Tofino is not for everyone. It's small, remote, and housing is expensive relative to local wages. But if you're a surfer, a nature lover, an artist, or someone who can work online from anywhere, it offers an incredibly unique lifestyle.

Many people describe Tofino as feeling like the "end of the road" – in a good way. You're literally at the edge of the continent.

Fun fact about Tofino: The area is known for **storm watching** in winter, when huge Pacific storms roll in. People actually travel there in the off-season just to sit in cozy lodges and watch the waves crash.

Links for Tofino and best-small-town lists:

<https://banffnationalpark.com/12-best-small-towns-in-british-columbia/>

<https://ca.finance.yahoo.com/news/best-towns-live-bc-113600693.html>

[OUTRO – ~2 minutes]

[On camera]

So there you have it – ****10 of the best places to live in British Columbia in 2026****.

From big, global Vancouver to charming Victoria, from rising-star Nanaimo to mountain-town Kimberley and surf-town Tofino, B.C. really offers almost every lifestyle you can imagine.

Remember, the “best” place depends on ****you**** – your budget, your job, your family situation, and what kind of climate and community you want. Use the links in the description to dig deeper into each of these places, check current housing costs, and see how they rank on livability and cost-of-living scales.

If you found this video helpful, hit like, subscribe to the channel, and let me know in the comments: which of these B.C. places would YOU most want to live in – big city, suburb, mountain town, or coastal village?

Thanks for watching, and I’ll see you in the next video.